



BEASTLY FACTS · CARE PACKAGE

AXOLOTL · AMBYSTOMA MEXICANUM ·
AMPHIBIAN

Give your axolotl cold, clean water from day one.

A complete, checked-fact printable manual: cold-water tank setup, water quality, diet, health triage, and the routines that keep an axolotl thriving for its full lifespan.

20 pages

Beginner to Intermediate

Print or tablet

Version 1.0 · August 2026



CONTENTS

What's inside

Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

GETTING STARTED

How to Use This Package	3
-------------------------	---

SECTION 01 · QUICK PROFILE

Quick Profile & Cost Overview	4
-------------------------------	---

SECTION 02 · FULL CARE GUIDE

Tank Size & Cold-Water Setup	5
Water Temperature & Quality	6
Diet & Feeding	7
Common Mistakes & Enrichment	8

SECTION 03 · HEALTH & COMMON ISSUES

Health Red Flags & What to Tell the Vet	9
Fungal Infection & Impaction	10
Heat Stress & Water Quality Burns	11

SECTION 04 · QUICK REFERENCE

Setup Checklist & Water Quality/Temperature Targets	12
Emergency & Quick Targets Card	13

SECTION 05 · OWNER TOOLS

Budget & Shopping List	14
First 30 Days & Days 31 to 90	15
Symptom Quick Reference	16
Daily, Weekly, Monthly & Seasonal Routine	17
Owner Log	18
Enrichment Checklist	19

REFERENCE

Glossary	20
----------	----

START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

If you haven't set up yet

Read pages 4 through 8 in order before buying anything. Tank size, cooling method, and water quality decisions are expensive to redo once an axolotl is already in the water. Get the tank size and cooling method right the first time, then use the Budget & Shopping List on page 14 to buy once.

If your axolotl is already set up

Jump to the Setup Checklist and Water Quality/Temperature Targets on page 12 to audit what you have, and the Health Red Flags section starting on page 9 if anything seems off.

Print these first

- | | |
|---|---|
| ☐ Page 12: Setup Checklist & Water Quality/Temperature Targets | ☐ Page 17: Daily, Weekly, Monthly & Seasonal Routine |
| ☐ Page 13: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 18: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 16: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 19: Enrichment Checklist |

WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

Axolotl care advice online varies wildly, especially around temperature and filtration. This package reflects current water-quality and cold-water husbandry standards, cross-checked against veterinary and aquatics sources, not recycled forum advice.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

An aquatic-experienced veterinarian. This is a husbandry reference for day-to-day care. Anything urgent or health-related is always a vet call, not a page in this book.

SECTION 01

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Scientific name	<i>Ambystoma mexicanum</i>
Adult size	9 to 12 in nose to tail
Captive lifespan	10 to 15 years typical with consistent care, occasionally longer
Diet type	Carnivore; earthworms or nightcrawlers are the nutritionally complete staple
Water temperature	60 to 68°F (never above 72°F)
Tank minimum	20-gal long for one; 40-gal breeder better for two
Housing	Species-only tank; no fish tankmates
Handling	Minimal; more handling-averse than most commonly kept reptiles/amphibians

Cost overview

The axolotl itself typically runs \$30 to \$100. Budget setup and ongoing costs on top of that.

Initial setup

\$200 to \$500 without a chiller (cool climates using fan-based cooling only), or \$450 to \$900 with a dedicated aquarium chiller.

Monthly ongoing

\$15 to \$45 for food, water conditioner, and filter media.

BUDGET FOR THE WORST CASE TOO

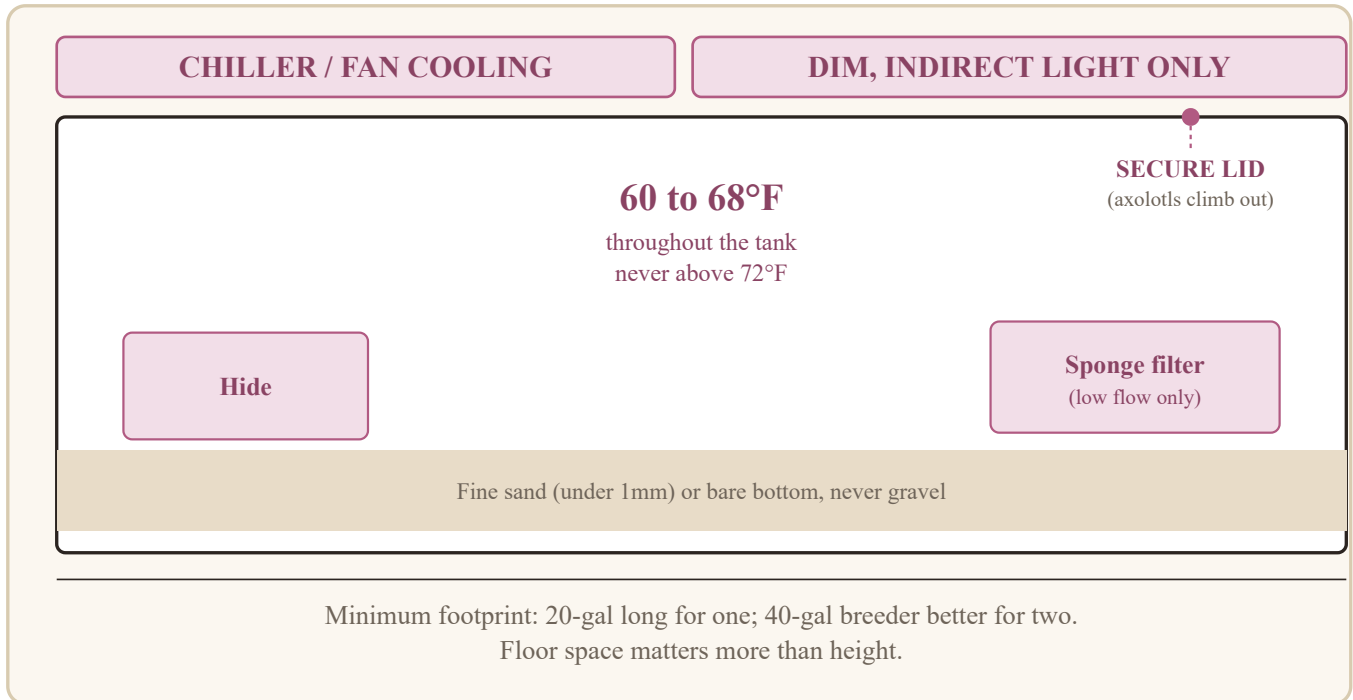
Vet treatment for impaction or a severe fungal infection can cost well beyond routine care. Neither is likely if you follow this package, but both are real enough to plan for. Ask your vet for a specific estimate rather than guessing.

Fun facts worth knowing

- Axolotls are neotenic: unlike most salamanders, they keep their external gills and stay fully aquatic for life instead of metamorphosing onto land.
- They have no eyelids, which is part of why bright light and glare are genuinely stressful for them, not just a lighting preference.
- A tank lid isn't just for looks. Axolotls can climb well enough to get out of an open tank.

Tank size & cold-water setup

A 20-gallon long tank is the minimum for one axolotl; a 40-gallon breeder works better for two. Floor space matters more than height since axolotls are bottom-dwellers that rarely swim to the surface by choice. A secure, weighted lid is required. Axolotls can climb well enough to get out of an open tank.



NEVER

Use a heater. In an axolotl's tank, warmth is the danger, not the fix. If your room runs warm, that's what a chiller or fan-based cooling is for, not a heater at any point.

What the diagram doesn't show

- Cycle the tank fully, ammonia at 0 ppm and nitrite at 0 ppm, before your axolotl goes in. See page 6.
- Species-only tank: no fish. Fish can nip at gills or outcompete axolotls for food.
- Juveniles under 5 inches: keep them on bare-bottom, not sand, until they're larger.
- If you use a canister filter instead of a sponge filter, diffuse the output through a spray bar. Axolotls dislike current.

Water temperature & quality

READING	TARGET
Water temperature	60 to 68°F
Stress threshold	Above 72°F, stress becomes chronic
Danger zone	Mid-70s°F and up, can be fatal
Ammonia	0 ppm
Nitrite	0 ppm
Nitrate	Under 10 ppm, ideally
pH	7.4 to 7.8

Cycling comes first

A tank needs to be fully cycled, ammonia holding at 0 ppm and nitrite holding at 0 ppm, before an axolotl goes in. An uncycled tank can't process waste fast enough, and ammonia or nitrite exposure is a water quality problem your axolotl will feel immediately. Test before you buy the animal, not after.

Cooling, not heating

Never use a heater. Use an aquarium chiller, or in a cool climate, fan-based cooling across the water's surface. Above 72°F, stress starts becoming chronic; by the mid-70s, conditions can turn fatal. A reliable cooling method is core equipment, not an accessory.

TEST REGULARLY, NOT JUST AT SETUP

Log water temperature, ammonia, nitrite, and nitrate in the Owner Log on page 18. A single good reading doesn't mean the tank is stable; a trend does.

Signs something's off

YOU NOTICE	LIKELY MEANS
Ammonia or nitrite above 0 ppm	Tank not fully cycled, or a water change is overdue
Nitrate creeping above 10 ppm	Water change overdue
Water temperature drifting above 72°F	Cooling isn't keeping up; check the chiller or fan setup
Curled or shrunken gills, red or irritated skin	Possible heat stress or water quality burn, see page 11

Diet & feeding

Axolotls are carnivores. Earthworms or nightcrawlers are the nutritionally complete staple, cut to size for juveniles. Sinking pellets, salmon-based or invertebrate-formulated, work well as a supplement. Bloodworms make a fine occasional treat, not a staple.

AGE	STAPLE	SUPPLEMENT/TREAT	FREQUENCY
Juvenile	Earthworms/nightcrawlers, cut to size	Sinking pellets as supplement	Daily
Adult	Earthworms/nightcrawlers	Sinking pellets; bloodworms as occasional treat	Every 2 to 3 days

Why the staple matters

Earthworms and nightcrawlers deliver complete, balanced nutrition on their own, which is why they're the staple rather than a rotation of equal options. Pellets are a convenient supplement, not a replacement for the staple. Bloodworms are worth offering occasionally for variety, but leaning on them as a regular meal skips most of what a worm-based diet provides.

NEVER FEED

Anything too large for your axolotl to swallow easily. Oversized food is one of the two main causes of impaction, along with loose or coarse substrate. See page 10.

Watch appetite as a health signal

A steady feeding response, every 2 to 3 days for adults or daily for juveniles, is one of the simplest health indicators you have. Log appetite in the Owner Log on page 18 so a slow change doesn't slip by unnoticed.

Common mistakes & enrichment

Mistakes that cause the most harm

- Using a heater, or letting room temperature drift into the 70s. Overheating is the single biggest killer of pet axolotls.
- Choosing gravel or small rocks as substrate, a leading cause of impaction.
- Keeping fish in the same tank. They nip at gills or outcompete axolotls for food.
- Running a filter with too much current. Axolotls dislike flow; keep it low with a sponge filter or a diffused spray bar.
- Adding an axolotl before the tank is fully cycled.
- Using bright lighting. Axolotls have no eyelids and are genuinely sensitive to bright light.
- Handling more than necessary, covered in detail below.

Handling

Handling should be rare and reserved for genuine necessity, such as a tank move or a vet-directed exam. Axolotls are more handling-averse than most commonly kept reptiles and amphibians: their skin is delicate, their external gills can be damaged by contact, and they don't tolerate time out of water well.

NEVER

Handle an axolotl more than necessary "just to hold it." If you must, use clean, wet hands or a soft wet net, and keep time out of water as short as possible.

Enrichment, by priority

Hides

A secure hide gives an axolotl somewhere to retreat, which matters for an animal with no eyelids and real light sensitivity.

Dim lighting

Keeping light low and indirect isn't just comfort, it's a genuine stress reducer for this species specifically.

Feeding variety

Rotating earthworms, pellets, and the occasional bloodworm treat gives some natural variation without changing the core diet.

Appropriate substrate

Fine sand or a clean bare bottom lets an axolotl move and forage naturally without an impaction risk.

Health red flags

What to watch for, and what to actually tell the vet.

CONTACT A VET PROMPTLY IF YOU SEE

Fuzzy white or gray patches on the skin or gills, curled gills, red or irritated skin, sudden lethargy, refusal to eat for an extended period, or a water temperature that has spiked above the safe range. Also call promptly if you've seen your axolotl ingest substrate or an oversized piece of food.

What to tell the vet

- ☐ Current water temperature, and how long it's been elevated if relevant
- ☐ Ammonia, nitrite, and nitrate readings
- ☐ What you feed and how often
- ☐ When symptoms started and whether they're worsening

Why water quality comes up first

Most of the conditions in this section, fungal infection, impaction, heat stress, and water quality burns, trace back to temperature or water quality more often than anything else. A vet will ask about your readings and your cooling setup before anything else for exactly that reason.

Normal vs. concerning

NORMAL	CONCERNING
Occasional brief hiding or reduced activity	Persistent lethargy with no clear trigger
Gills that puff out during feeding or activity	Gills that stay curled or shrunken at rest
Skiping a meal occasionally	Refusing food for an extended stretch
Normal skin tone for your axolotl's coloring	New red or irritated patches on the skin

Fungal infection & impaction

Fungal Infection

Signs: fuzzy white or gray patches on the skin or gills. **Response:** correct temperature and water quality first, this is usually the underlying trigger, then cooler water changes and salt baths. For cases that persist despite correcting husbandry, a vet-prescribed antifungal is the next step.

PREVENTION BEATS TREATMENT

Correct water temperature (page 6) and clean, well-cycled water prevent most fungal cases before they start. This is the single highest-leverage thing on this page.

Impaction

Cause: ingesting substrate or an oversized piece of food. **Response:** for mild, early cases, fasting and cooler water under vet guidance sometimes resolves it. Surgery is reserved for blockages that don't pass on their own.

DON'T WAIT TO "SEE IF IT RESOLVES"

If you suspect impaction, especially if your axolotl stops eating or you know it ingested substrate or an oversized item, call a vet promptly. This is exactly the scenario the substrate and feeding guidance on pages 5 and 7 is meant to prevent.

Heat stress & water quality burns

Cause: temperature spikes or poor water quality. **Signs:** curled gills, lethargy, red or irritated skin. **Response:** an immediate water change and temperature correction; see a vet if the animal doesn't improve quickly or if signs are severe.

THE SINGLE BIGGEST KILLER

Overheating is the single biggest killer of pet axolotls. Above 72°F, stress becomes chronic; by the mid-70s, it can be fatal. A reliable cooling method isn't optional gear, it's the one piece of equipment that keeps your axolotl alive through warm weather.

What raises the risk

- Room temperature swings during warm months, especially without air conditioning
- Skipped water changes, letting ammonia or nitrite build up
- A tank that isn't fully cycled yet (see page 6)
- Overstocking a tank relative to its filtration capacity

Why the two causes get grouped together

A temperature spike and a water quality problem produce overlapping signs, curled gills, lethargy, irritated skin, because both are stress on the same system. The response is the same either way: fix the water first, then reassess. Don't wait to see which cause it was before acting.

CHECK BOTH, EVERY TIME

When you see these signs, test water temperature and ammonia/nitrite/nitrate together. Treating one while ignoring the other is a common way this recurs.

Setup checklist & water quality/temperature targets

Essential setup checklist

- ☐ 20-gal long tank minimum (40-gal breeder for two)
- ☐ Secure, weighted lid
- ☐ Sponge filter, or canister with spray bar (low flow)
- ☐ Aquarium chiller or fan-based cooling method
- ☐ At least one hide
- ☐ Fine sand (under 1mm) or bare-bottom substrate
- ☐ Dim lighting setup, no bright or direct light
- ☐ Water test kit (ammonia, nitrite, nitrate, pH)
- ☐ Earthworm/nightcrawler and sinking pellet supply lined up
- ☐ Tank fully cycled before the axolotl goes in

Water quality & temperature targets

TARGET	RANGE
Water temperature	60 to 68°F (never above 72°F; mid-70s+ can be fatal)
Ammonia	0 ppm
Nitrite	0 ppm
Nitrate	Under 10 ppm, ideally
pH	7.4 to 7.8

Before your axolotl comes home

- ☐ Tank fully cycled, ammonia and nitrite both holding at 0 ppm
- ☐ Water temperature confirmed stable and holding in range
- ☐ Cooling method (chiller or fan setup) tested and working
- ☐ Earthworm/nightcrawler and pellet source lined up before day one

Emergency & quick targets

CALL AN AQUATIC VET NOW IF

Fuzzy white/gray patches on skin or gills · curled gills, lethargy, or red/irritated skin · water temperature spiked above the safe range · ingested substrate or oversized food and stopped eating · refusal to eat for an extended period

READING	TARGET
Water temperature	60 to 68°F (never above 72°F)
Ammonia	0 ppm
Nitrite	0 ppm
Nitrate	Under 10 ppm, ideally
pH	7.4 to 7.8
Feeding frequency	Adults every 2 to 3 days · juveniles daily

HAVE THIS READY WHEN YOU CALL

Water temperature, ammonia/nitrite/nitrate readings, what and when you last fed, and when symptoms started.

Budget & shopping list

ITEM	TYPICAL COST
Tank (20-gal long or larger)	\$50 to \$150
Filtration (sponge filter, or canister + spray bar)	\$20 to \$120
Aquarium chiller	\$100 to \$400
Substrate (fine sand)	\$10 to \$25
Hides/accessories	\$40 to \$80
Total initial setup, no chiller	\$200 to \$500
Total initial setup, with chiller	\$450 to \$900
The axolotl itself	\$30 to \$100
Monthly ongoing (food, conditioner, filter media)	\$15 to \$45

PLAN FOR, DON'T COUNT ON AVOIDING

Vet treatment for impaction or a severe fungal infection can cost well beyond routine care. Ask your vet for a specific estimate, and keep a small emergency fund regardless.

WHERE NOT TO CUT CORNERS

The cooling system is the line item most directly tied to the single biggest killer of pet axolotls: overheating. A fan-based setup can work in a genuinely cool climate, but if your room runs warm for any stretch of the year, a real aquarium chiller isn't optional equipment. Save on decor and extras before you save here.

First 30 days & days 31 to 90

Week 1

- ☐ Confirm water temperature and ammonia/nitrite/nitrate with an actual test kit, not by eye
- ☐ Let your axolotl settle: minimal handling, focus on feeding and observing appetite
- ☐ If you're planning a wellness check, do it while your axolotl is still settling in, not after something looks wrong

Week 2 to 3

- ☐ Establish a consistent feeding schedule: daily for juveniles, every 2 to 3 days for adults
- ☐ Start testing water weekly and logging results
- ☐ Start the Owner Log on page 18

Week 4

- ☐ Review the Owner Log for a steady temperature and water quality trend, not just single readings
- ☐ Confirm the chiller or fan-cooling setup is holding temperature as expected
- ☐ Introduce first enrichment items from page 19

Days 31 to 90

- ☐ Keep testing water parameters on a regular schedule, don't stop once things look stable
- ☐ Look back at the Owner Log for any slow drift in temperature, water quality, appetite, or gill condition
- ☐ Start rotating enrichment on the monthly schedule from page 19
- ☐ Reassess your cooling method before the first warm season it has to handle

Symptom quick reference

SYMPTOM	LIKELY CAUSE	ACTION
Fuzzy white/gray patches on skin or gills	Fungal infection	Correct temp/water quality; vet if persistent (page 10)
Curled gills, lethargy, red/irritated skin	Heat stress or water quality burn	Water change + temp correction; vet if severe (page 11)
Ingested substrate or oversized food, won't eat	Possible impaction	Vet promptly (page 10)
Water temperature above 72°F	Overheating risk	Correct cooling immediately (page 6)
Ammonia or nitrite above 0 ppm	Tank not cycled, or water change overdue	Water change; retest (page 6)
Nitrate above 10 ppm	Water change overdue	Water change (page 6)
Refusal to eat, extended period	Several possible causes	Vet visit, bring the Owner Log (page 18)
Axolotl out of tank / escaped	Lid not secure	Secure lid immediately, check for injury (page 5)

Daily, weekly, monthly & seasonal routine

Daily

- ☐ Check water temperature
- ☐ Feed per the age-based schedule on page 7 (juveniles daily, adults every 2 to 3 days)
- ☐ Quick visual check: appetite, gill condition, behavior

Weekly

- ☐ Test ammonia, nitrite, nitrate, and pH
- ☐ Partial water change as your readings call for
- ☐ Wipe down glass and check filter flow is still low
- ☐ Log readings in the Owner Log on page 18

Monthly

- ☐ Review the Owner Log for slow trends, not just single readings
- ☐ Check chiller/fan performance and filter media condition
- ☐ Inspect substrate cleanliness and depth

Seasonal

- ☐ Reassess room temperature swings between summer and winter
- ☐ Confirm your cooling method still holds 60 to 68°F during the hottest part of the year

SECTION 05 · OWNER TOOLS

Owner log

Photocopy this page, or track digitally. Consistency matters more than the format.

DATE	TEMP °F	NH3	NO2	NO3	APPETITE	GILLS	NOTES

WHY BOTHER LOGGING

A steady water quality and temperature trend is the single best early warning system you have. Most of the conditions in this package show up as a water reading or appetite change before anything else is visible.

Equipment log

ITEM	LAST CHECKED	NEXT CHECK/REPLACE BY
Chiller / cooling fan		
Filter media		
Test kit reagents		

Vet visit log

DATE	REASON	FOLLOW-UP

Enrichment checklist

Setup

- ☐ At least one hide, placed for easy access
- ☐ Dim lighting confirmed, no bright or direct light reaching the tank
- ☐ Substrate appropriate for current size (bare-bottom if under 5 inches)

Monthly review

- ☐ Vary feeding style (scatter vs. placed) for natural foraging behavior
- ☐ Reassess whether the hide and substrate still fit your axolotl's current size
- ☐ Confirm lighting is still dim as the tank ages or is repositioned

Enrichment log

DATE	ACTIVITY	HOW IT WENT

Glossary

Neoteny	The retention of larval features, like external gills, into adulthood. Axolotls stay aquatic and never undergo full metamorphosis.
Ammonia	A toxic waste byproduct in aquarium water. Should read 0 ppm in a healthy, cycled tank.
Nitrite	A toxic intermediate product of the nitrogen cycle. Should read 0 ppm.
Nitrate	The less-toxic end product of the nitrogen cycle. Kept ideally under 10 ppm with regular water changes.
Cycling	Establishing beneficial bacteria in a tank so it can process ammonia and nitrite before an animal is added.
Impaction	A gastrointestinal blockage, often from substrate or oversized food.
Sponge filter	A low-flow filter using a porous foam block and gentle air-driven suction, well suited to axolotls' dislike of current.
Spray bar	A perforated tube on a filter's return line that diffuses outflow into a wide, gentle stream, used to keep canister filter current low.
Chiller	A device that actively cools aquarium water, the primary way to keep temperatures safely in range in a warm climate.

Compiled from veterinary and aquatics sources, cross-checked against current Beastly Facts guides at time of publication. This package is a husbandry reference, not a substitute for an aquatic-experienced veterinarian, and is not a live website mirror. No external links or website CTAs appear in this document.

© Beastly Facts · Version 1.0 · August 2026